

Technical Writing Cheat Sheet

The Three Pillars

Pillar	Definition	Goal
Legibility	Can the text be physically read?	Clear fonts, good contrast, proper formatting
Readability	Can sentences be easily parsed?	Short sentences, simple structure
Comprehensibility	Can the meaning be understood?	Clear explanations, logical flow

Sentence Guidelines

Length Rules

- **Target:** 10-15 words per sentence
- **Maximum:** 20 words
- **Vary rhythm:** Mix short and medium sentences

Structure

- ✓ Subject → Verb → **Object** (active voice)
- x **Object** → was Verb-ed → **by** Subject (passive voice)

- ✓ "The system validates the input."
- x "The input is validated by the system."

Avoid Recursion

✗ Bad: "The module that processes the data that comes from the API that connects to the server..."

✓ Good: "The module processes API data. The API connects to the server."

Word Choice

Instead of	Use
utilize	use
implement	do, make
leverage	use
facilitate	help, enable
subsequently	then
prior to	before
in order to	to
at this point in time	now
in the event that	if

The Four-Step Explanation

1. **Definition:** What is it?
2. **Theorem:** What does it do?
3. **Proof:** How does it work?
4. **Conclusion:** Why does it matter?

DEFINITION: A cache stores frequently accessed data.

THEOREM: Caching reduces database load.

PROOF: Instead of querying the database each time,
the system checks the cache first.

CONCLUSION: This improves response time by 10x.

Style Rules

Contractions

- **Formal writing:** Don't use don't
- **Informal/tutorials:** Contractions are fine

Articles (a/an)

- Use “a” before consonant sounds: a user, a URL
- Use “an” before vowel sounds: an API, an hour

Tense Consistency

- x "The function calculates the value and returned the result."
- ✓ "The function calculates the value and returns the result."

Avoid Ego

- x "I developed this feature..."
- x "We implemented..."
- ✓ "This feature provides..."
- ✓ "The system implements..."

Document Structure

1. Title (clear, specific)
2. Table of Contents (for 3+ pages)
3. Introduction (what & why)
4. Prerequisites (what readers need)
5. Main Content (the how)
6. Examples (working code)
7. Troubleshooting/FAQ
8. References/Further Reading

Editor's Pet Peeves

Grammar

Wrong	Right
less items	fewer items
amount of users	number of users
data is	data are
criteria is	criterion is / criteria are

Spelling

Wrong	Right
occured	occurred
seperate	separate
definately	definitely
accomodate	accommodate

Technical Terms

Wrong	Right
indexes (DB)	indices
vertexes	vertices
matrixes	matrices

Quick Checklist

Before publishing:

- ☐ Average sentence length < 20 words?
- ☐ Active voice used?
- ☐ Simple words preferred?
- ☐ Consistent tense throughout?
- ☐ No “I/we” in formal docs?
- ☐ Spell check run?
- ☐ Technical terms correct?
- ☐ Examples tested and working?

The Golden Rule

“If you can’t explain it simply, you don’t understand it well enough.” — Often attributed to Einstein

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